

The Boston Globe

Serving our community since 1872

WEDNESDAY, JULY 16, 2025

After fire, increased scrutiny of assisted living



JOHN TLUMACKI/GLOBE STAFF
A bouquet of flowers sat on the front steps while investigators examined the scene at Gabriel House.

Officials call for more regulation of affordable homes, changes in financing

By Jason Laughlin and Marin Wolf
GLOBE STAFF
and Ava Berger
GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

Top Massachusetts officials are suggesting the state consider new ways to regulate and finance so-called affordable assisted living homes after the deadly fire Sunday night at the facility for seniors in Fall River that relies heavily on public funding.

“It’s very challenging to finance them,” said Robin Lipson, the state’s chief official for elder

services, during a meeting of a commission created last year to improve long-term care in the state. “The rents are deeply discounted, so there’s not cash coming in to make renovations to the building.”

The fire at the Fall River facility, known as Gabriel House, killed nine elderly residents and sent around 30 more to hospitals. Fire officials have not yet determined the cause of the blaze.

More than 75 percent of Gabriel House residents are enrolled in Medicaid, state officials

Hitting back

Fall River’s fire chief denied staffing was necessarily a factor, dismissing a union official’s claim as speculation. **B1.**

have said, and it charges significantly less than a typical assisted living facility does for private-paying patients. Built in 1964, Gabriel House had been the subject of several complaints from family members about living conditions.

Lipson, secretary of the Executive Office of Aging and Independence, or AGE, raised the

possibility that such facilities because they are so dependent on government housing or Medicaid payments, “should be regulated or supported in a different way” from those that rely on private payers.

There are about 20 affordable assisted living homes in Massachusetts, said state Representative Thomas Stanley, the Waltham Democrat who sponsored legislation to improve conditions in assisted living facilities last year. He said lower income adults are particularly ill-

GABRIEL HOUSE, Page A10

“I want to enjoy my summer, have fun like a normal kid, but I can’t be a kid anymore. I need to be an adult.”

MARCELO GOMES DA SILVA



JESSICA RINALDI/GLOBE STAFF
Marcelo Gomes da Silva hung out with his little brother, Miguel, in a Dairy Queen in Milford. The teen had spent six days in ICE detention, with his case drawing national attention. Gomes faces a new normal as his senior year approaches.

In the spotlight, a face of immigration

By Marcela Rodrigues
GLOBE STAFF

MILFORD

Marcelo Gomes da Silva was eating chicken strips with his two younger siblings at his local Dairy Queen, when he noticed a middle-aged woman approaching their booth.

“I saw you coming in and I had to say something,” the woman told Gomes, who spread a warm, welcoming smile across his face, his braces on full display.

“I’m so sorry for what happened to you,” she said. “God bless you.”

Gomes, a Brazilian national who was detained by ICE officers on May 31 on his way to volleyball practice at his high school, has quickly become the face of the Trump adminis-

After ICE detention, Milford teen Marcelo Gomes da Silva navigates the highs and lows of fame

tration’s aggressive ICE operations in Massachusetts.

The 18-year-old has decried the conditions he experienced during the six days he was detained in local and national media interviews, shared his story with Governor Maura Healey, who presented him a rosary blessed by Pope Francis, and has been routinely stopped by strangers in public, such as the woman in the Dairy Queen, who want to share their views about immigration policy.

Some ask for a photo or thank him for speaking out about the conditions of detention. Others tell him he doesn’t belong in the United States.

Gomes is confronting his newfound celebrity as he also must grapple with his family’s vulnerable sta-

GOMES, Page A6

Shelter food deal raises questions

Nonprofit gave board member’s company the catering without a bid

By Deirdre Fernandes
GLOBE STAFF

After Valley Opportunity Council, a Chicopee nonprofit, landed a multimillion-dollar contract with Massachusetts in 2023 to manage a shelter for homeless and migrant families, its leaders had to find a caterer to provide meals for the residents.

They didn’t look far.

By March of that year, they had tapped Key Food Marketplace, a local grocery chain, to deliver dinners to 93 families staying at the Quality Inn in Chicopee. The owner of Key Food, local businessman Tony Diaz, also had a history with the nonprofit as one of 18 volunteer members of Valley Opportunity Council’s board of directors.

Key Food won the job without submitting a written bid or even signing a written contract. Diaz’s company doesn’t appear on invoices Valley Opportunity Council regularly submitted to the state.

Officials with Massachusetts’ Executive Office of Housing and Livable Communities, which oversees the state’s shelter system, became aware Diaz was providing food last November, state officials said, after receiving an anonymous complaint. That was more than a year and half after the shelter opened.

Stephen Huntley, executive director of Valley

SHELTER FOOD, Page A10



DANIELLE PARHIZKARAN/GLOBE STAFF
A BOSTON CAMEO — Star attraction Caitlin Clark was in town Tuesday night as the Indiana Fever took on the Connecticut Sun in the second-ever WNBA game at TD Garden. The Fever won, 85-77. **C1.**

Midnight broil

Wednesday: Hot, humid. High 85-90. Low 73-78.
Thursday: More of the same. High 84-89. Low 75-80.
Sunrise: 5:22 Sunset: 8:18
Weather and Comics, G6-7. Obituaries, C9.

A Blue Line train got stuck under Boston Harbor during the evening commute, stranding hundreds of passengers who had to be led out of the tunnels. **B1.**

Inflation rose last month to its highest level since February as President Trump’s tariffs pushed up costs. **B5.**

An obesity study upended common wisdom, suggesting diet is the major culprit. **A4.**



A new model for CSA uses data to maximize efficiency, and delivers to your door. It won’t be just beets. **G1.**

The National League won the All-Star Game in novel fashion, taking a first-ever home run derby after blowing a 6-0 lead. **C1.**

With Boston voters checked out, mayoral campaigns battle on the air

By Emma Platoff
GLOBE STAFF

There are less than two months until the first votes are cast in the Boston mayor’s race. But at this point in the summer, most voters are more focused on beach days and barbecues than on ballots.

So candidates and their aligned super PACs are turning to the airwaves to capture attention, launching ads on television and radio that tout their

messages and tear down their opponents. It’s one way to continue reaching voters even during the humid haze of July, when in-person forums are few and far between, and politics is not top of mind for most.

It’s also yet another indication that in this expensive campaign, many of the battles are taking place over the air.

Ads aren’t a silver bullet for winning a campaign. But at this point in the summer, “it’s all

you can do, really,” said Cam Charbonnier, a Boston political consultant who ran a mayoral campaign in 2021.

“People aren’t really making a decision at this point, and a lot of people aren’t totally focused on it,” he added. “But by the time they start to think about it, you don’t want it to be the first time they’re hearing about your candidate. You want them to have an idea that’s

MAYORAL CAMPAIGN, Page A5



VOL. 308, NO. 16
*
Suggested retail price
\$4.00